

Into the Wild

Developed by Mary Kay Harrington with contributions from Shirley Hargis, John R. Edlund, and Marcy Merrill

MODULE: STUDENT VERSION

Module Text

Krakauer, Jon. *Into the Wild*. 1996. Anchor Books, 2015.

Reading Rhetorically

Text – Krakauer, *Into the Wild*

Preparing to Read

Activity 1: Getting Ready to Read – Quickwrite

Into the Wild is a nonfiction, full-length text by Jon Krakauer. Published in 1996, it is based on an article Krakauer wrote in *Outside Magazine* about Christopher McCandless, a young college graduate who went off to Alaska and died in the woods. Because Krakauer's article drew a huge amount of mail to the magazine, he decided to write a book about this interesting character. Chris McCandless was an idealistic young man who formed a life philosophy based on his experience and his reading in college. His idealism, ironically, led to his death by starvation. He made choices that seemed foolish as we look at them now. But McCandless genuinely loved the outdoors and wanted to live in the world without all the trappings of money and his middle-class upbringing. *Into the Wild* is, in a way, a mystery story. We're unsure as to why McCandless rejected his family, why he was so angry with them, and why he chose to head for Alaska.

Quickwrite: Write for three to five minutes on the prompt of your choice.

1. Think about your experience in hiking, backpacking, and/or existing in the wild. What are the benefits of any one of these activities?
2. Recall a friend or family member who prefers the outdoors and is adventurous. Why do you think this person is so infatuated with the outdoors?
3. What alternative plans do you have to begin college immediately after high school? What might you do? Why would you do it, and for how long could you see yourself doing that activity?
4. Think about an experience you have had when you were alone and made some misjudgments that could have led to disaster but didn't. (It doesn't have to be in the outdoors.) What miscalculations did you make and how did you avoid disaster?

Keep this initial quickwrite in your *Into the Wild* notebook.

Activity 2: Exploring Key Concepts

We know about characters from their actions, their thoughts, their spoken words, their appearance, and comments others make about them. This book explores a character, Chris McCandless, and the actions he takes. Before reading about him, complete this pre-reading activity. Read the scenarios below, and use specific words to describe the character in the scenario. In groups, you will compare your lists and then turn in your finalized list of descriptive words to your teacher.

Mary was from the Valley. She used the word “like” in front of most of her adjectives when she spoke, and she talked quite a bit. On her sixteenth birthday, she expected to get a car. It was a given. Her friends thought she would get a pink Maserati, but she was sure her parents would buy her the candy-apple red Alfa Romeo. The day of her birthday came, and as she peered out her bedroom window, she noticed a new car in the driveway, but it was yellow—surely not hers. She thought it may have been the new cleaning woman’s. She did not see any other car in the long driveway. She ran down to get a closer look. It was a new canary-colored convertible Volkswagen bug. On the front driver’s seat was a birthday note to her. She burst into tears and ran into the house.

Words to describe **Mary**:

Vandana had a comfortable life. Not unlike her friends, Vandana had gone to school, had done well, and soon was to attend the university. She had received several scholarships and her parents had planned to pay for the rest of her education. Vandana hoped to help people in her future career but hadn’t quite decided in which field she wanted to do this. She decided to take a year off before attending college. Her parents refused her this. She worked hard the summer before she was to go to college and made enough money for a one-way ticket to India. She had been interested in the life of Buddha and wanted to learn more about him. Leaving a note for her parents, she headed off to India in hopes of discovering a spiritual and centered path for herself.

Words to describe **Vandana**:

Emory was very popular and made friends easily. People were drawn to his honest nature and his free spirit. It was odd when two of his classmates saw drawings he had made to build bombs in his math notebook. It was even odder when he took off one day without a word to his teachers or friends. His parents notified the police. When they did a search of his room, they found two small guns and threatening notes he had written to a former girlfriend a year earlier.

Words to describe **Emory**:

Activity 3: Surveying the Text

- As you count the number of chapters in the text, read a few of the chapter titles. What do the titles have in common?
- Read a few of the short epigraphs that come before a chapter begins. (An epigraph is a relevant quotation at the beginning of a book, a chapter, etc.) Do they seem to have a common thread? What do you know about them and their authors?
- Look at the length of the book.
- Look at any maps or photographs.
- Identify the author and publication date.
- What other works has Krakauer written? What do you know of them? Have you read any of them?

From these clues, what do you think the book is about? How do you think it is organized? Write your predictions in your notebook.

Activity 4: Making Predictions and Asking Questions

Krakauer wrote an article entitled “Death of an Innocent” in 1993. He followed the path of Chris McCandless in the pages of *Outside Magazine*. He later expanded the article into a book, and in 2007, Sean Penn made the book into a movie. For interviews and more background on the book and movie, go to the *Outside Magazine* Web site for an article by Diana Saverin (www.outsideonline.com/outdoor-adventure/Back-Into-the-Wild.html). Then answer the following questions in your notebook.

1. What do you know or assume about a magazine called *Outside Magazine*? Who do you think the intended readers are?
2. Why do you think Krakauer wrote this particular book?
3. What do you think made this story so popular? What do you think people found engaging about it?

Activity 5: Making Predictions and Asking Questions – The Author’s Note

Many readers skip the author’s note that begins a book, but this note by Krakauer is particularly interesting and will guide your reading of his book. Read the three-page author’s note before you begin to read the work. Then form groups of three or four and discuss the following questions:

1. What might McCandless’s motives have been for his behavior (paragraph 3)?
2. How difficult would it be to invent a new life?
3. In paragraph 4, Krakauer introduces some themes of the book. Discuss these themes.
4. In paragraph 5, Krakauer warns us that he will not be an impartial biographer. What does this mean? Are all biographers impartial? What might we expect from Krakauer?
5. In the last paragraph, Krakauer introduces the complexity of Chris McCandless. Keep in mind the following four questions as you read the text:
 - Should we admire McCandless for his courage and noble ideas?
 - Was he a reckless idiot?
 - Was he crazy?
 - Was he an arrogant and stupid narcissist?

After the class discussion, write your response to the author’s note in your notebook. After reading the author’s note, what do you expect to find in the rest of the book?

Activity 6: Understanding Key Vocabulary – Stopping to Understand New or Difficult Words

Vocabulary Self-Assessment Chart for Before, During, and After Reading

Directions: Place a +, =, or – sign next to the word at each phase of the reading.

Key: + I know it well, = I have heard of it, – I do not know it

	Before I read	While I read	After I read
Chapter 1			
unsullied			
sonorous			
meandered			
Chapter 2			
trough			
permafrost			
derelict			
anomaly			
environs			
enigmatic			
Chapter 3			
itinerant			
estranged			
nomadic			
unencumbered			
emancipated			
Chapters 4-7			
intermittent			
emasculated			
indolently			
espoused			

Activity 7: Understanding Key Vocabulary – Keeping a Vocabulary Reading Log

Because the setting in this text helps to move the story along as we follow McCandless from one location to another and through difficult weather conditions, the author uses descriptive words to present the conflict weather presents for him. Keep a log of all words that you come across in your reading of the text that relates to the raw weather conditions. Include the word, the definition of the word, and a picture of the word (if possible). Use these words to increase your vocabulary and enhance your writing as you write about the book and better understand the difficult circumstances McCandless faces.

Activity 8: Understanding Key Vocabulary – Vocabulary Word Learning Strategies

Return to your adjectives (descriptive words) generated in Activity 2 and circle the adjectives that characterize McCandless. Add any other adjectives that describe him. You may believe McCandless is a narcissist. Here are some questions to help you understand this term better.

- Ask a question: What do you think narcissist means?

- Word Associations: Of these four options, which word is synonymous with a narcissist and why?
 - a) sacrificing
 - b) egotistic
 - c) altruistic
 - d) glorious

- Derivation: Where have you heard this word before?

- Who do you know like this? Describe a person you think is narcissistic. What behaviors make you think they exhibit this characteristic?

- Idea Completions: Always needing attention and changing clothing to look his best all day long, it was obvious...

Activity 9: Creating Personal Learning Goals

Consider the learning goals that the module author set for *Into the Wild*. What do these learning goals mean to you? Highlight one or two of the goals that seem worthwhile for you to work on while you read this book. After a thorough reading and engaging in class discussions about the text, you will write a blended human-interest story for a magazine comparing either yourself or a friend/family member to McCandless. *Into the Wild* is your mentor text. With the reading and writing process in mind, add any other goals you would like to set for yourself. Then, turn to a partner and share your goals. Choose at least two goals to write in your notebook. Explain the steps you plan to take to reach your goals. For example, if you want to “positively contribute to ongoing conversations of lasting importance” but often have difficulty sharing your thoughts in class, you may set the personal goal of contributing to small group and class discussions at least three times a week.

- Analyze how ideas, events, and/or narrative elements interact and develop over the course of a full-length text.
- Analyze the extent to which the writer’s arguments anticipate and address reader concerns and counterclaims.
- Understand key rhetorical concepts such as audience, purpose, context, and genre through analysis of texts.
- Make effective rhetorical choices in light of audience, purpose, and occasion.
- Positively contribute to ongoing conversations of lasting importance.
- Use the author’s writing as a mentor text to make connections between the main character and ones’ self or a friend/family member.
- Write a human-interest article for a magazine with clear explanations, relevant stories, and well-supported arguments.

Text – Chapters 1-2

Reading Purposefully

Activity 10: Reading for Understanding

Read chapters 1-2. Your teacher may choose to give you class time and may even read some of the text aloud. However, be prepared to read on your own. Use sticky notes to annotate the text as you read. Note questions you have, reactions to what has happened, and vocabulary challenges. Read the epigraphs that appear before each chapter and keep track of the authors to whom Krakauer refers. In addition, study the maps provided in the book to get a geographical grounding for the journey McCandless takes.

As you journey through each section of the text, keep your notes, questions, and observations in your *Into the Wild* notebook. Each assigned reading section will have its own questions to answer, but you will do certain tasks throughout the book. Some of these activities require you to maintain a geographical record of where and when McCandless is in the book. Another is to keep track of the literary quotations that Krakauer uses in his epigraphs. Because you are studying McCandless's personality to discover why he made the decisions he did, you will keep a log of McCandless's personality traits.

Discussing Chapters 1-2

Break into groups to discuss the first reading of chapters 1 and 2. As you discuss the chapters, note key vocabulary words in the text that were difficult for you. Discuss word meanings with your group and enter the words that apply to characterization and setting in your vocabulary logs.

1. Note the epigraphs that begin each of these chapters. Discuss the possible importance of the postcard by McCandless that begins chapter 1 and the quotation from McCandless followed by a quotation from *White Fang*, by Jack London in chapter 2.
2. In your notebook, make note of all the maps that begin the text.
3. What is your assessment of Chris McCandless so far?

Text – Chapter 3

Activity 11: Reading for Understanding – First Reading

Read chapter 3 and write down your thoughts on the following questions in your notebook:

1. What was Westerberg like? What kind of character did he have?
2. What was McCandless like? What kind of character did he have? Would you have liked to know him?
3. Why did McCandless start calling himself Alex instead of Chris? Did this make a difference in how he related to people?

Discuss your answers in your small groups.

Text – Chapters 4-7

Activity 12: Reading for Understanding

Read chapters 4-7. Continue to use sticky notes to annotate.

Study the map that begins chapter 4 and refer to it as you follow McCandless's journey. Jot down answers to the following as you read these chapters:

1. In your notebook, list the people McCandless met along the way.
2. What was it about McCandless's personality that made an impression on people?
3. Note McCandless's journal. Why do you think he avoided using the first person when he talked about himself? Why doesn't he use the pronoun "I"?
4. What is the purpose of chapter 4?
5. Characterize Ronald Franz. What kind of human being was he? Did he have your sympathy? Why or why not?
6. What more did you learn about McCandless's relationship with his father? Do you think his anger is justified? Why or why not?

Discuss answers together, such as why McCandless avoids using the first person when he writes in his journal. Back up your answers with textual evidence. This begins the process of backing up your theories or your ideas with the information you can find from the text but it also provides opportunities for deep thinking as you must come up with answers based on support from the text.

Text – Chapters 1-7

Activity 13: Reading for Understanding – Revisiting Predictions

Now that you have read chapters 1-7, open your notebook to the predictions you made in Activity 4. Answer the following questions:

1. Which of your predictions turned out to be true?
2. What surprised you?
3. If your prediction was inaccurate, what in the text misled you?
4. What, if anything, is confusing to you?
5. Why is the author telling you this story?
6. How has the author changed what you understand about the situation?
7. Who is the author and how has the author's perspective and attitude influenced your thoughts about McCandless and his situation?

Activity 14: Annotating and Questioning the Text

Our first reading of a book gives us the storyline, the major conflicts, and a sense of what the author intends. The second (or third) reading provides richer analyses and a deeper understanding of the text. In the author's notes, Krakauer provides a guide to our reading—especially to our subsequent reading of *Into the Wild*.

Annotating a text enables readers to explore more deeply how a text works to inform or persuade its readers. During the initial reading, you were encouraged to read “with the grain,” or “to play the believing game.” In rereading, you should read “against the grain,” or “play the doubting game.” This is where the conversation shifts and the reader begins to question the text and the author. As you reread the text, annotate it by making marginal notations (e.g., asking questions, expressing surprise, disagreeing, elaborating, and noting any instances of confusion). As you look at the text again, one clue as to what might be worth annotating is to go back to the four questions Krakauer raises in his “Author's Note.”

1. Was McCandless admirable for his courage and noble ideas?
2. Was he a reckless idiot?
3. Was he crazy?
4. Was he a narcissist who perished out of arrogance and stupidity—and was he undeserving of the considerable media attention he received?

Use sticky notes to make marginal notes as you reread the text. When you respond to the chapter questions, cite the text, if necessary, where you find evidence for your judgments.

Annotating Chapters 1-2

1. Each chapter begins with a short epigraph (a quotation that is relevant to that chapter). Now that you have a better sense of Chris McCandless's story, why do you think these epigraphs are relevant to these chapters?

Annotating Chapter 3

2. How would you characterize McCandless's relationships with other people: his parents, his sister, Westerberg?
3. What did his friends make of his secretive life?

Annotating Chapters 4-7

As you read, see if you can find evidence of McCandless's preparation for Alaska.

Consider reading more parts of works that McCandless admired and quoted, such as Thoreau's "On the Duty of Civil Disobedience," and think of how McCandless might have incorporated Thoreau's advice into his life philosophy.

You might also read some of Jack London's work that we know influenced McCandless: *The Call of the Wild*, *White Fang*, "To Build a Fire," "An Odyssey of the North," or "The Wit of Porportuk."

4. Based on your prior knowledge of these texts McCandless read and/or your new findings, why did these works appeal to McCandless? Reread the notes at the end of chapter 7 that McCandless sent to his friends.

5. What are his tone and attitude? To what extent do you agree or disagree with this opinion?

Activity 15: Negotiating Meaning

Now that you have completed the first seven chapters of *Into the Wild*, take a few minutes to consider your challenges with the chapters. What has caused you difficulty, both as you have read and as you have discussed key concepts? Make a list of your difficulties and share them with a partner. Discuss how you have overcome some of these difficulties to make meaning or how you might do so in the future.

Then, work with your partner to identify which chapter seems the most developed and why. Once you and your partner have reached consensus, join another two people and discuss your choices for the most developed chapter.

Activity 16: Examining the Structure of the Text

Work with a partner to discuss the following questions. Use sticky notes to make notes in your book, and record questions or ah-ha's in your notebook. Be prepared to discuss the Descriptive Outline of the chapters and any burning questions with your class.

Mapping Chapters 1-2

1. Contrast chapters 1 and 2. What is the purpose of each?
2. The main character of the book is dead by the second chapter. Why does Krakauer begin the story at the end?
3. Draw a line where you think the introduction ends in each chapter or use a sticky note to indicate the line. Is it after the first paragraph or after several paragraphs?
4. Consider the last paragraph of each chapter. What is the function of each? How does each paragraph work?

Mapping Chapter 3

As you reconsider this chapter, analyze the various relationships in the context of the entire book. Create a chart or map of how people are related and where they are located. Also, be sure to capture Chris's interactions with them, supposed feelings or impressions of them, and his involvement with them.

5. What is the point of focusing on Carthage, South Dakota, and on Westerberg in this chapter?
6. How does this chapter function in terms of the organization of the whole?
7. Make a Descriptive Outline of chapter 3 by marking the introduction and conclusion of the chapter. As you look at each section of the chapter, discuss with your partner what the text says versus what it does (highlighting the difference between content and rhetorical purpose).

Mapping Chapters 4-7

8. Write brief statements describing the function of each of these chapters for the reader. What is Krakauer trying to accomplish?

Chapter 4:

Chapter 5:

Chapter 6:

Chapter 7

9. How do these chapters work as a whole?

Activity 17: Analyzing Rhetorical Grammar

Read the assigned selections below and then explain who the speaker is in the extracted sentences.

Selection 1:

“He seemed extremely intelligent,” Franz states in an exotic brogue that sounds like a blend of Scottish, Pennsylvania Dutch, and Carolina drawl. “I thought he was too nice a kid to be living by that hot springs with those nudist and drunks and dope smokers.” After attending a church that Sunday, Franz decided to talk to Alex “about how he was living. Somebody needed to convince him to get an education and a job and make something of his life.”

When he returned to McCandless’s camp and launched into the self-improvement pitch, though, McCandless cut him off abruptly. “Look, Mr. Franz,” he declared, “you don’t need to worry about me. I have a college education. I’m not destitute. I’m living like this by choice.” And then, despite his initial prickliness, the young man warmed to the old-timer, and the two engaged in a long conversation. (51)

Now read the following extracted sentences. In each case, determine who is speaking. Is the person speaking directly, or is someone repeating what another person has said? How do you know?

1. “He seemed extremely intelligent,” Franz states.
2. After attending a church that Sunday, Franz decided to talk to Alex.
3. “Look, Mr. Franz,” he declared, “you don’t need to worry about me.”
4. The young man warmed to the old-timer.

Write a one sentence summary that states the purpose of this passage in the book.

Selection 2:

At one point, to reward McCandless with a task that involved slightly more skill, Westerberg attempted to teach him to operate a front-end loader. "Alex hadn't been around machinery much," Westerberg says with a shake of his head, "and it was pretty comical to watch him try to get the hang of the clutch and all those levers. He definitely wasn't what you'd call mechanically minded."

Nor was McCandless endowed with a surfeit of common sense. Many who knew him have commented, unbidden, that he seemed to have great difficulty seeing the trees, as it were, for the forest. "Alex wasn't a total space cadet or anything," says Westerberg; "don't get me wrong. But there were gaps in his thinking. I remember once I went over to the house, walked into the kitchen, and noticed a god-awful stink. I mean it smelled nasty in there. I opened the microwave, and the bottom of it was filled with rancid grease. Alex had been using it to cook chicken, and it never occurred to him that the grease had to drain somewhere. It wasn't that he was too lazy to clean it up—Alex always kept things really neat and orderly—it was just that he hadn't noticed the grease." (62-63)

Read the following extracted sentences. In each case, determine who is speaking. Is the person speaking directly, or is someone repeating what another person has said? How do you know?

1. Westerberg attempted to teach him to operate a front-end loader.
2. "Alex hadn't been around machinery much," Westerberg says.
3. Many who knew him have commented, unbidden, that he seemed to have great difficulty seeing the trees, as it were, for the forest.
4. "Alex wasn't a total space cadet," says Westerberg.
5. "It wasn't that he was too lazy to clean it up."

What is the purpose of this passage? What is the point of Westerberg's story about the chicken grease? Is he making fun of McCandless?

After reading the passages above, consider the following questions:

1. Were you ever confused about who was speaking? If so, what caused the confusion?
2. What is the difference in effect on the reader between direct quotations, paraphrases or summaries?
3. Choose two of the sentences above and rewrite them in a different grammatical pattern. For example, if the sentence is a direct quotation, revise it as a paraphrase or summary.

Examples:

- “Alex hadn’t been around machinery much,” Westerberg says.
Westerberg assumed that Alex hadn’t been around machinery much.
- Westerberg attempted to teach him to operate a front-end loader.
Westerberg insisted, “Let me teach you to operate a front-end loader.”

As you continue to read *Into the Wild* and other texts, notice the different effects of using direct quotations, paraphrases, and summaries. Notice the punctuation used in each situation. In your own writing, consider the effect on the reader of quotations, paraphrases, and summaries, and double check to make certain your punctuation is correct.

Activity 18: Analyzing Stylistic Choices

Analyzing Stylistic Choices helps you see the linguistic and rhetorical choices writers make to inform or convince readers. Precise writers make linguistic choices to create certain effects. They want to have their readers react in a certain way. Go back through the text to analyze Krakauer's use of words, sentences, and paragraphs, and take note of how effective a writer he is.

Analyzing Chapters 1-2 – Words

As you revisit these chapters, pay attention to the denotative and connotative meanings of key words. Think about the effect certain words have on you. Krakauer describes McCandless's body in a very clinical way. Reread that description:

Virtually no subcutaneous fat remained on the body, and the muscles had withered significantly in the days or weeks prior to death. At the time of the McCandless's remains weighed sixty-seven pounds. Starvation was posited as the most probable cause of death. (14)

1. How are you affected by this description?
2. Look again at the words in the vocabulary list that relate to the harshness of Alaska. Are you interested in traveling there sometime? Why or why not?
3. Why does understanding the new words matter?

Analyzing Chapters 1-2 – Sentences

Consider the sentence structure Krakauer uses.

4. How varied are his sentences?
5. What effects do sentence structure and length have on the reader?

Analyzing Chapter 3 – Denotation/Connotation

Consider the connotations of some of the word choices Krakauer makes. For example, he describes Westerberg as “drawn into a scheme to build and sell ‘black boxes,’ which illegally unscramble satellite-television transmissions, allowing people to watch encrypted cable programming without paying for it” (19).

6. Is Krakauer sympathetic to Westerberg? How do you know?
7. Compare the language and tone of the two letters that McCandless writes, one to his sister and one to his parents. What did McCandless mean when he said, “They will think they have bought my respect”? (21)

Analyzing Chapters 4-7 – Paragraphs

A few pages from the end of chapter 7, Krakauer gives us an analysis of McCandless's relationship with his father and mother (it begins, "Westerberg's latter conjecture..." (64).

8. What is the tone of this paragraph?
9. Does Krakauer cite any evidence that suggests he "knows" his analysis is accurate?
10. Does it matter?

Questioning the Text

Activity 19: Summarizing and Responding

Summarizing is a very important skill used to extract the main ideas from a text and explain what the author says about them. You have reread the text and looked at how each chapter fits into a whole. In a way, you have “mapped” the text. Now you can generate a summary from that mapping.

1. Write a one-sentence summary of chapters 1-7. If a friend who hadn't read it asked you what it is about, what would you say? Write your answers in your notebook. Your teacher may give you the opportunity to share your writing with a small group or whole class.
2. Ron Franz taught McCandless how to do leatherworking. Krakauer writes,

...for his first project, McCandless produced a tooled leather belt, on which he created an artful pictorial record of his wanderings. ALEX is inscribed at the belt's left end; then the initials C.J.M (for Christopher Johnson McCandless) frame a skull and crossbones. Across the strip of cowhide one sees a rendering of a two-lane blacktop, a NO U-TURN sign, a thunderstorm producing a flash flood that engulfs a car, a hitchhiker's thumb, an eagle, the Sierra Nevada, salmon cavorting in the Pacific Ocean, the Pacific Coast Highway from Oregon to Washington, the Rocky Mountains, Montana wheat fields, a South Dakota rattlesnake, Westerberg's house in Carthage, the Colorado River, a gale in the Gulf of California, a canoe beached beside a tent, Las Vegas, the initials T.C.D., Morro Bay, Astoria, and at the buckle end, finally, the letter N (presumably representing north). Executed with remarkable skill and creativity, this belt is as astonishing as any artifact Chris McCandless left behind. (51-52)

Near the end of chapter 7, Westerberg says of the belt,

“Alex used to sit at the bar in the Cabaret and read that belt for hours on end,” ... “like he was translating hieroglyphics for us. Each picture he'd carved into the leather had a long story behind it.” (68)

Considering what you know of McCandless so far, why does he make the belt? What does it represent to him? Why does he feel a need to explain it to others? What stories does it tell? In what sense is the belt a summary of McCandless's life up to that point?

3. If you were going to make a belt that told the story of your own life, what would you put on it?

Activity 20: Thinking Critically

Rhetorical appeals are the accepted ways in which we persuade or argue a case. Read the following quotations and consider the questions that follow. Choose the quotation that is most meaningful to you and answers the questions in your notebook. Also, consider how that quotation affects you as a reader. Are you influenced by the logic, are you emotionally affected, or are you convinced because of Krakauer's ethos? You will find yourself understanding further how Krakauer persuades the audience and how you can use these same techniques to persuade others when you write or speak.

Write answers to these questions in your notebook and be ready to discuss them with your classmates.

1. At the end of chapter 2, Krakauer says of McCandless,

Driving west out of Atlanta, he intended to invent an utterly new life for himself, one in which he would be free to wallow in unfiltered experience. To symbolize the complete severance from his previous life, he even adopted a new name. No longer would he answer to Chris McCandless; he was now Alexander Supertramp, master of his own destiny. (22-23)

These are some pretty strong assertions about what McCandless was trying to do. Do you believe them at this point? Has Krakauer supported these conclusions about McCandless? What are some of the evidence he presents?

2. In chapter 6, Krakauer writes,

On March 14, Franz left McCandless on the shoulder of Interstate 70 outside Grand Junction and returned to southern California. McCandless was thrilled to be on his way north, and he was relieved was well—relieved that he had again evaded the impending threat of human intimacy, of friendship, and all the messy emotional baggage that comes with it. He had fled the claustrophobic confines of his family. He'd successfully kept Jan Burres and Wayne Westerberg at arm's length, flitting out of their lives before anything was expected of him. And now he'd slipped painlessly out of Ron Franz's life as well. (55)

Does Krakauer actually know what McCandless was feeling at that point? How can he tell? What evidence does he have? Do you think he is right?

3. In chapter 6, McCandless writes to Ron Franz, telling him,

You are wrong if you think joy emanates only or principally from human relationships. God has placed it all around us. It is in everything and anything we might experience. We just have to have the courage to turn against our habitual lifestyle and engage in unconventional living.

My point is that you do not need me or anyone else around to bring this new kind of light in your life. It is simply waiting out there for you to grasp it, and all you have to do is reach for it. The only person you are fighting is yourself and your stubbornness to engage in new circumstances. (57-58)

Does McCandless offer any evidence for these assertions about life? Are his life and his journey arguments for or against this position? Is Ron Franz convinced? Are you?

Preparing to Read

Activity 21: Surveying the Text

As you may have noted previously, the chapters in this book are all labeled with place names or descriptions. Taking what you know about the previous part of the book and what the chapter titles below imply, what do you think the next chapters will be about? You may want to do some Internet searches on some of the place names. In some cases, you will find that the same name is shared by different places, and you will have to use reasoning to determine which one is likely to appear in this book.

Write down your predictions in your *Into the Wild* notebook.

Chapter 8 – Alaska

Chapter 9 – Davis Gulch

Chapter 10 – Fairbanks

Chapter 11 – Chesapeake Beach

Chapter 12 – Annandale

Chapter 14 – The Stikine Ice Cap

Chapter 15 – The Stikine Ice Cap

Activity 22: Making Predictions and Asking Questions

By chapter 7 of the book, it is pretty clear what Chris McCandless was like, where he went on his journey, and what happened to him. What questions about McCandless remain to be answered? What larger themes and questions could be discussed? What will Krakauer write about in the rest of the book? Write your predictions about the upcoming chapters in your *Into the Wild* notebook.

Activity 23: Understanding Key Vocabulary – Stopping to Understand New or Difficult Words

Vocabulary Self-Assessment Chart for Before, During, and After Reading

Directions: Place a +, =, or – sign next to the word at each phase of the reading.

Key: + I know it well, = I have heard of it, – I do not know it

	Before I read	While I read	After I read
Chapters 8-10			
hubris			
requisite humility			
contrived asceticism			
theatrics			
enigmatic			
compulsive			
copious			
circuitous			
labyrinth			
flamboyant			
ephemeral			
overwrought			
Chapters 11-13			
taciturn			
mercurial			
“marches to a different drummer”			
nuance			
inequities			
sanctimonious			
hypocrite			
obliquely			
extemporaneous			

insurrectionists			
Chapters 14-15			
zeal			
demarcates			
penitent			
inebriated			
phantasmagoria			
madrigal			
extricated			
recumbent			
epiphany			
crampon			
volition			

Reading Purposefully

Activity 24: Reading for Understanding

As you journey through each section of the text, keep your notes, questions, and observations in your *Into the Wild* notebook. Each assigned reading section will have its own questions to answer, but you will do certain tasks throughout the book. Some of these activities require you to maintain a geographical record of where and when McCandless is in the book. Another is to keep track of the literary quotations that Krakauer uses in his epigraphs. Because you are studying McCandless's personality to discover why he made the decisions he did, you will keep a log of McCandless's personality traits.

In chapters 8-9, Krakauer describes other figures who have disappeared into the wild, including their personalities and histories. The two chapters put the McCandless story into a larger context.

Read chapters 8-10. More than likely you will be reading most of the text on your own and perhaps at home. After you have read the chapters, take notes in your notebook to answer the following questions and be prepared to discuss them in class.

1. What is the function of these chapters? What is their relationship to the rest of the text?
2. Chapter 8 opens with some reactions from people to the article about McCandless that Krakauer published in *Outside Magazine*. What do most people think? Why did Krakauer put this material here in the middle of the book?
3. Why did Krakauer interrupt the McCandless story with chapters 8-9?
4. Were you surprised that McCandless left trails so that the authorities could find out who he was?
5. What's in a name? Does it matter that we have the name we were given by our parents? How do names matter? Does your name fit you? If not, what name would you choose? Why?

Text – Chapters 11-13

Activity 25: Reading for Understanding

Read chapters 11-13. These three key chapters give background information that will help you piece together the mystery of McCandless. Chapter 11 fills in his personal past; chapter 12 fills in his family past, and chapter 13 chronicles the grief of McCandless's family. Jot down the surprises (if any) that you encountered as you read. Be prepared to discuss your answers in a small group or whole class.

1. What was McCandless like as a child and as a teen? What was he like as an adult? Were there indications throughout his life as to the kind of person he would become?
2. Do you think you are essentially the same person you were as a child?
3. How have you changed?

Text – Chapters 14-15

Activity 26: Reading for Understanding

Read chapters 14-15. You may want to use sticky notes to mark surprises and answers to the following questions which you will be discussing in class.

1. Why does Krakauer talk about himself in these two chapters?
2. Do you think it was a good idea for Krakauer to interject himself into the story?
3. What is your reaction to his description of his own climbing experience?
4. How is Krakauer's life related to McCandless's?
5. John Menlove Edwards said that climbing is a "psycho-neurotic tendency." Do you think that is so? Always?
6. Do you think that Edwards defines McCandless? How is he psychoneurotic?

Text – Chapters 8-15

Activity 27: Examining the Structure of the Text

Outlining Chapters 8-10

Briefly outline each of these chapters and explain its function. Consider Krakauer's purpose in each of these chapters.

Chapter 8:

Chapter 9:

Chapter 10:

In a small group discussion (triads) share your answers. Each group member should share a chapter description and function, being certain to discuss what the purpose of each chapter was. Then, discuss the following questions:

1. How important is it for us to compare McCandless with Rosellini, Ruess, and Waterman?
2. Why did Krakauer give us these details?

Outlining Chapters 11-13

These chapters give us important background knowledge. How would reading the book have been different had you known in advance the information Krakauer gives in these chapters?

1. Would the book have been more effective if Krakauer had used a different organizing strategy?

2. What if the book had been told in chronological order, beginning when McCandless was a small child and ending with his death? Take a stand on whether this would have been better than Krakauer's organization. You may even have other ideas for the organization.

Outlining Chapters 14-15

1. Are these two chapters necessary to the overall structure of the text?
2. Krakauer gives his thesis early in chapter 14:

My suspicion that McCandless's death was unplanned, that it was a terrible accident, comes from reading those few documents he left behind and from listening to the men and women who spent time with him over the final year of his life. But my sense of Chris McCandless's intentions comes, too, from a more personal perspective. (134)

Do you agree with Krakauer's position? Is it possible that McCandless died accidentally? Write your thoughts in your notebook. Then, share with others in your class as a "thirty-second expert." Stand up/hand up/pair up to share. After each of you has shared for thirty seconds, you will find a new partner to share your thoughts. After sharing with three partners, return to your seat and reflect on what you have heard. Do you still agree or not? Add any additional thoughts to your notebook.

Activity 28: Annotating and Questioning the Text

Our first reading of a book gives us the storyline, the major conflicts, and a sense of what the author intends. The second (or third) reading provides richer analyses and a deeper understanding of the text.

In the author's notes, Krakauer provides a guide to our reading—especially to our subsequent reading of *Into the Wild*.

1. Now it is time to read “against the grain,” or “play the doubting game.” This is when the conversation shifts and the reader begins to question the text and the author. As you reread the text, annotate it by making marginal notations (e.g., asking questions, expressing surprise, disagreeing, elaborating, and noting any instances of confusion).
2. As you look at the text again, one clue as to what might be worth annotating is to go back to the four questions Krakauer asks in his “Author’s Note.”
 - Was McCandless admirable for his courage and noble ideas?
 - Was he a reckless idiot?
 - Was he crazy?
 - Was he a narcissist who perished out of arrogance and stupidity—and was he undeserving of the considerable media attention he received?

Make marginal notes as you reread the text. When you respond to the chapter questions, cite the text, if necessary, where you find evidence for your judgments.

Annotating Chapters 8-10

Reread chapter 8 and consider the charges by others against Krakauer.

1. Should they be taken seriously? Why or why not?
2. Study the map that begins chapter 9 and follow Ruess’s journey.

Annotating Chapters 11-13

Consider McCandless’s family history.

1. Does that change your view of him?
2. Characterize each of McCandless’s family members. What are their strengths and weaknesses?
3. Was McCandless reasonable in his reaction to his parents’ past? Should he have forgiven them?
4. How do you think the information about his parents’ difficulties early in their relationship affected McCandless?
5. Does his anger at them explain something about McCandless’s choices in life?
6. Chapter 12 ends with McCandless’s mother talking about a dream (nightmare?) that she had. Have you ever had such a thing happen to you? Should we take dreams such as these seriously? Why or why not?

Annotating Chapters 14-15

1. Think about and then jot down the comparisons you see between McCandless's relationship with his father and Krakauer's relationship with his.
2. Do you think Krakauer understands McCandless? Why or why not?
3. Do you think Krakauer reads too much into McCandless's life because he feels some sort of affinity to him?
4. Respond to the following quotation at the end of chapter 15:

It is easy, when you are young, to believe that what you desire is no less than what you deserve, to assume that if you want something badly enough, it is your God-given right to have it. (155)

Activity 29: Analyzing Stylistic Choices

Precise writers make linguistic choices to create certain effects. They want to have their readers react in a certain way. Return to the text and analyze Krakauer's use of words, sentences, and paragraphs, and take note as to how effective a writer he is.

Analyzing Chapters 8-10

In the first part of chapter 8, Krakauer quotes Alaskans who had opinions about McCandless and his death.

1. Why does Krakauer cite these letters? How does citing them add to or detract from the text?
2. Choose one of these letters and respond to it, explaining the degree to which you agree or disagree.
3. Krakauer inserts himself into the story in chapter 8. Does this give him more credibility or do you find it annoying? Why or why not?

Analyzing Chapters 11-13

Reread aloud the next-to-last paragraph in chapter 13, where Krakauer powerfully describes Billie's grief.

1. Rephrase the paragraph and simplify it in your own words.

2. What makes Krakauer's description (quoted below) powerful?

It is all she can do to force herself to examine the fuzzy snapshots. As she studies the pictures, she breaks down from time to time, weeping as only a mother who has outlived a child can weep, betraying a sense of loss so huge and irreparable that the mind balks at taking its measure. Such bereavement, witnessed at close range, makes even the most eloquent apologies for high-risk activities ring fatuous and hollow. (132)

3. What is the implication of Krakauer's last comment above?

Analyzing Chapters 14-15

Krakauer uses technical vocabulary related to mountain climbing in these two chapters. Investigate the meaning of technical words you don't know. What is the effect of these words on the reader?

Questioning the Text

Activity 30: Summarizing and Responding

Chapters 1-7 describe McCandless's journey and death. Chapters 8-15 try to put McCandless' life in a larger context by comparing him to other people: other wanderers, his family, and the author of the book. Look over your notes and annotations and answer the following questions. Write your answers in your notebook:

1. How does McCandless compare with the other wanderers Krakauer describes? In what ways is McCandless similar? In what ways is he different? Do we understand McCandless better after making these comparisons?
2. Krakauer and others have speculated that McCandless was estranged from his family because of his relationship with his father. What was his family life like? Does it explain his later behavior?
3. Krakauer clearly feels a strong connection to McCandless. Do you think they were very similar? Why or why not? In what ways is this book as much about Krakauer as it is about McCandless?
4. Taking your notes and your answers to the above questions into account, write a short paragraph answering the following question: Who was Chris McCandless?

Activity 31: Thinking Critically

The following questions will help you discover how Krakauer persuades the audience and how you can use these techniques to persuade others when you write or speak. Discuss possible answers with a shoulder partner before you write your answers in your notebook.

1. What do the author's style and language tell you about him?
2. Krakauer argues in chapter 14 that McCandless's death was unplanned and was a terrible accident (134). Does the book so far support that position? Do you agree with Krakauer? Why or why not?
3. Chapters 14 and 15 describe Krakauer's successful attempt when he was 23 years old to climb the "Devil's Thumb," a mountain in Alaska. He also describes what he thinks are parallels between McCandless and himself. Do these chapters increase his credibility for writing this book, or do they undermine his credibility by making it seem like he has his own agenda and is not objective?
4. When he accidentally burns a big hole in his tent, which actually belongs to his father, he is more worried about his father's reaction than the cold. How does this detail affect you as the reader?

Text – Chapters 16-18, Plus Epilogue and Afterword

Preparing to Read

Activity 32: Surveying the Text

As you may have noted previously, the chapters in this book are all labeled with place names or descriptions. The remaining chapters are named after places that are already familiar with other parts of the book. Taking what you know about the previous part of the book and what the chapter titles below imply, what do you think the next chapters will be about? Write your discoveries in your notebook.

- Chapter 16: The Alaskan Interior
- Chapter 17: The Stampede Trail
- Chapter 18: The Stampede Trail
- Epilogue
- Afterword (added in 2015 edition)

Activity 33: Making Predictions and Asking Questions

You are nearing the end of the book. You are probably already thinking

1. What part of the story remains to be told?
2. What questions remain unanswered?
3. How will Krakauer end the book?

Write your predictions in your notebook.

Activity 34: Understanding Key Vocabulary – Stopping to Understand New or Difficult Words

Vocabulary Self-Assessment Chart for Before, During, and After Reading

Directions: Place a +, =, or – sign next to the word at each phase of the reading.

Key: + I know it well, = I have heard of it, – I do not know it

	Before I read	While I read	After I read
Chapters 16–18			
Rubicon			
perambulation			
claustrophobic			
lacerations			
malevolent			
repertoire			
resilience			
insidiously			
Epilogue			
epilogue			
anomalous			
Afterword			
smoldering			
ambiguous			
macabre			
neurolathyrism			

Reading Purposefully

Activity 35: Reading for Understanding

As you read the concluding chapters, the epilogue, and afterword, keep your notes, questions, and observations in your *Into the Wild* notebook. Continue to keep track of the literary quotations that Krakauer uses in his epigraphs. Because you are studying McCandless's personality to discover why he made the decisions he did, continue to keep a log of McCandless's personality traits.

Reading Chapters 16–18: Into the Alaskan Wild

1. After a long detour, Krakauer brings us back to the scene of McCandless's death. What does Krakauer discuss in these chapters that he did not discuss in the previous chapters? Why did he delay presenting this information?
2. Krakauer provides a lot of quotations from McCandless's journal in these chapters. What is McCandless talking about? Why did Krakauer include these selections?
3. Krakauer quotes one of McCandless's friends, who said that McCandless "was born into the wrong century. He was looking for more adventure and freedom than today's society gives people" (174). Do you think this is true?

Reading the Epilogue: Grief

4. What was your initial sense of McCandless's mental condition compared to what you think now? Have you changed your mind?
5. What was your reaction to his parents as they visited the bus?

Reading the Afterword: Proof

6. Krakauer first published the book in 1996. Why did he take time from his life to continue the research and add this chapter in 2015?
7. What was the importance of the paper Krakauer co-authored titled "Presence of L-canavanine in *Hedysarum alpinum* seeds and its potential role in the death of Chris McCandless"? Specifically, why was it important that the paper was published in the peer-reviewed journal *Wilderness and Environmental Medicine* (211)?
8. Although Krakauer acknowledges that this new evidence may not persuade many Alaskans to view Chris McCandless differently, how do you think it affected his family and what effect did it have on you?

Activity 36: Annotating and Questioning the Text

In the “Author’s Note” at the beginning of the book, Krakauer introduces the complexity of Chris McCandless. His words imply the following four questions, which we have been considering throughout the book:

1. Should we admire McCandless for his courage and noble ideas?
2. Was he a reckless idiot?
3. Was he crazy?
4. Was he an arrogant and stupid narcissist?

Make marginal notes as you reread the text. When you respond to the chapter questions, cite the text, if necessary, where you find evidence for your judgments. At this point in your reading, have your answers to these questions changed in any way?

Activity 37: Examining the Structure of the Text

1. In chapter 17, Krakauer does not arrive at the bus until after about four pages. In those first pages, he gives us the details of the equipment he carries, the flow of the river, and the others with him. Is this necessary? What does it add? What does it detract?
2. Krakauer says that McCandless had a kind of “idiosyncratic logic.” Explain Krakauer’s meaning and the extent to which you agree or disagree with him.
3. What is the effect of having an epilogue that focuses entirely on the parents’ return to the bus? Does it provide closure?
4. What is the effect of having an afterword dedicated to some new evidence? What does it tell you about Krakauer’s perseverance?

Activity 38: Analyzing Stylistic Choices

Precise writers make linguistic choices to create certain effects because they want their readers to react in a certain way. Go back through the text and analyze Krakauer's use of words, sentences, and paragraphs. Then decide how effective his writing is.

Analyzing Chapters 16-18

Read aloud the last paragraph in chapter 18.

1. How does Krakauer know that McCandless "was at peace, serene as a monk gone to God"?
2. Does Krakauer have the right to infer from the photograph that McCandless had the serenity of a monk?
3. What is an alternative interpretation of the photograph?

Analyzing the Epilogue

Read aloud the last paragraph of the epilogue.

4. Is the language literary? Why or why not? What is its effect on you?

Analyzing the Afterword

5. What is the tone of the afterword? How is it different than previous chapters?

Questioning the Text

Activity 39: Summarizing and Responding

In chapter 18, Krakauer reports that some cabins stocked with food and emergency gear were located about three hours upstream from the bus where McCandless died. However, after McCandless had been found dead, a wildlife biologist in the area discovered that the cabins had been vandalized. He said,

“It was obviously not the work of a bear,” Atkinson reports. “I’m a bear technician, so I know what bear damage looks like. This looked like somebody had gone at the cabins with a claw hammer and bashed everything in sight. From the size of the fireweed growing up through mattresses that had been tossed outside, it was clear that the vandalism had occurred many weeks earlier.” (196)

Some people blamed McCandless, saying that he was angry that civilization had intruded into his wilderness. Others said that there was no evidence that McCandless had even walked that way. Considering everything you know about McCandless—his journey, his character, his ideas—do you think that he was capable of trashing these cabins? After reading this book, do you know McCandless well enough to know whether or not he would do this? Write a paragraph in your notebook about your thoughts.

Activity 40: Thinking Critically

As you examine Krakauer's use of rhetoric, you will understand how he persuades his audience and how you can use these techniques to persuade others when you write or speak. Work in triads. Look at all questions carefully. Number off one to three for each group member to focus on one question. Take five minutes to answer your question in your notebook. When you finish your question, answer the fourth question. Then, discuss your answers in your triads.

1. In chapter 16, Krakauer says that McCandless

...seemed to have moved beyond his need to assert so adamantly his autonomy, his need to separate himself from his parents. Maybe he was prepared to forgive their imperfections; maybe he was even prepared to forgive some of his own. McCandless seemed ready, perhaps, to go home. (168)

Do you agree with Krakauer's assessment?

2. Look at McCandless's response to several passages in Tolstoy's "Family Happiness" toward the end of chapter 16:

He was right in saying that the only certain happiness in life is to live for others...

I have lived through much, and now I think I have found what is needed for happiness. A quiet secluded life in the country, with the possibility of being useful to people to whom it is easy to do good, and who are not accustomed to have it done to them; then work which one hopes may be of some use; then rest, nature, books, music, love for one's neighbor—such is my idea of happiness. And then, on top of all that, you find a mate, and children, perhaps—what more can the heart of a man desire? (169)

Does this indicate a change in McCandless? Was he ready to "go home"?

3. Does Krakauer prove his hypothesis that McCandless's death was an unplanned accident?
4. How do chapters 16-18 affect you emotionally? Give specific examples.

Activity 41: Synthesizing Multiple Perspectives

Krakauer had outdoor experiences that he reflected on at times in the book and appeared to identify with McCandless in many ways. What if he relied so much on his own experiences that he made incorrect assumptions about McCandless's experiences? What if he had not been so sympathetic in his recounting of McCandless's story? What if a totally objective journalist had told the story? What would be different about the writing?

Consider this story told from a different perspective. Answer these questions with that person in mind:

- What would _____ say about this?
- How would _____ tell this story?
- What words would he or she use?

Your teacher will assign you a role. You will have twenty minutes to write McCandless's story from the perspective you are assigned. As you write the story, use specific language to match your character. Then, you will meet with another classmate who has a different perspective and have a conversation. After the conversation, give your classmate feedback on how effectively he/she portrayed the character's thoughts about McCandless.

Activity 42: Reflecting on Your Reading Process

1. There is still so much unknown about Chris McCandless and his journey. What do you want to learn next?
2. What reading strategies did you use or learn in this module?
3. Which strategies will you use in reading other texts and in other classes?
4. In what ways has your ability to read and discuss texts like this one improved?

Preparing to Respond

Discovering What You Think

Activity 43: Considering Your Task and Your Rhetorical Situation

As you consider the writing prompt, use your notebook to create a quick PAPA square. Your PAPA square may change throughout the writing process. Yet, it will serve as an outline for your planning.

Jon Krakauer first wrote an article for *Outside Magazine* to report on the puzzling circumstances of Christopher McCandless' death in Alaska. Krakauer became so absorbed in the story, perhaps, in part, due to the connections he made with McCandless, that he continued the investigation and turned his 9,000-word article into a best-selling 203-page book. Now that you have completed the book, including the afterword that Krakauer added in 2015, consider your connections to McCandless. In what ways are you like McCandless and how are you different? If you find very few similarities, think of a friend or family member who may remind you of McCandless. How does that person compare/contrast with McCandless?

Write a blended human-interest story for *Outside Magazine* (or a similar publication) that compares and contrasts either yourself or another person you know to McCandless. Be sure to define the kind of person McCandless was and how you/this other person compares. Develop your points with clear explanations, relevant stories, and well-supported arguments. Be specific in your comparison, using at least two strong references to the novel.

As you plan and write your article, don't dwell on the death of McCandless but on his life choices. Krakauer described him as "an extremely intense young man" who "possessed a streak of stubborn idealism that did not mesh readily with modern existence" (Author's Note, par. 6). Those who read your article should come away with a clear image of McCandless and an understanding of the comparison/contrast. Your argument may be a call to action, as McCandless gave Ron Franz, an 81-year-old man, when he wrote in a letter, "Don't settle down and sit in one place. Move around, be nomadic, make each day a new horizon. You are still going to live a long time, Ron, and it would be a shame if you did not take the opportunity to revolutionize your life and move into an entirely new realm of experience" (57). It could also be a plea to young people who are adventurous to use caution and to be considerate of family members when they choose adventure.

Purpose:

Audience:

Stylistic Choices:

Argument:

Persona:

Activity 44: Gathering Relevant Ideas and Materials

Return to your notebooks. Examine your quickwrites and comparisons to McCandless throughout your reading. How did you relate to McCandless as you read the book? If you didn't relate, who did you most think of as you read and reflect? That is the person you more than likely will want to use for your article.

In your notebook use a Venn diagram to compare/contrast McCandless to yourself or the friend/family member you have chosen.

Activity 45: Developing a Position

As you write your compare/contrast article, you will want to have a strong claim and well-supported arguments to convince your audience of your stance for both Krakauer and the comparison.

In determining your own stance about McCandless, consider the opinions of the various people he met on the road, the opinions of his family, Krakauer's own views, and what Krakauer calls "the prevailing Alaska wisdom," along with various statements by McCandless himself. What do you believe your readers will think about McCandless, his ideas and his quest? What do you think? How will you best present and support your views for your audience?

One way to get some perspective about the person you are comparing to McCandless is to imagine how other people would make the comparison. If you are writing about yourself, how would your mother make the comparison? Your best friend? A teacher? An adversary? For a friend/family member, you can also consider others' perspectives.

Now think about your own stance. After you have reflected on the following questions, form triads and present your plans to two classmates. Listen carefully to your classmates' plans and give feedback to them, commenting both on what you find convincing about their plans and how they might make improvements.

- What is the gist of your argument in one or two sentences? Turn these sentences into a working thesis statement.
- What would you say is your main claim at this point in time?
- How do your ideas relate to what others have said?
- What arguments or ideas are you responding to?
- What evidence best supports your argument or claim? What evidence might you use in relation to what others say about your argument? How does it support your claim?
- What background information does the reader need to understand your argument?
- What will those who disagree with you have to say about your argument? What evidence might they use to refute your ideas?

Writing Rhetorically

Composing a Draft

Activity 46: Making Choices about Learning Goals

Look in your notebook to review the goals you set in Activity 9. Those goals may have been based on the module author's goals or you may have personalized them. Regardless, rate yourself on a scale of one to four on each goal. Use the following rubric:

1. Oops! I didn't make any improvement.
2. I've shown some signs of improvement.
3. I still have work to do but am doing much better.
4. I've got this! I'm ready to set a new goal.

Give a reason for your rating. For example, "My goal was to positively contribute to ongoing conversations of lasting importance. I rated myself a three because I've been talking in a small group, and even some during lunch, about Chris McCandless's choices and how it affected his family. However, I sometimes find myself not speaking up in whole group discussions as I don't know if my comments are worthwhile."

As we near the end of the module and you complete your article, set one or two new goals for yourself. Focus on the upcoming writing assignment. In your notebook, make a plan for achieving your goals.

Activity 47: Making Choices as You Write

At this point, you have considered the topic and know who you are going to compare. You are aware of your stance toward the issue and you have gathered evidence from your notes and reading to support your ideas. Return to *Outside Magazine* online and study the structure of feature stories to get ideas for your introductions and conclusions. If you need a guide, identify a mentor text and follow the format.

Your task now is to compose the first draft of your article. You have some time to compose your draft in class but may need to continue it on your own time. Work in Google Docs or save your work as you go. Don't worry too much about spelling and grammar in this first draft. What's most important now is to get your ideas on paper or on your screen. You can adjust the presentation to your audience during the revision process.

Relax and write!

Activity 48: Negotiating Voices – Using the Words of Others

One of the most important features of academic writing is the use of words and ideas from written sources to support your own points. There are essentially three ways to incorporate words and ideas from sources, as shown below:

- **Direct Quotation:** Jon Krakauer says, “I had been granted unusual freedom and responsibility at an early age, for which I should have been grateful in the extreme, but I wasn’t” (148).
- **Paraphrase:** In chapter 11 of *Into the Wild*, Walt, McCandless’s father, remembers an early hike with twelve-year-old Chris. They made it to 13,000 feet before turning back from the 14,256-foot summit in Colorado. Chris did not want to quit and complained all the way down (109).
- **Summary:** In *Into the Wild*, Krakauer seems to be working out his own past and his relationship with his own father as well as telling the sad story of Chris McCandless. Because Krakauer, too, is a man of the outdoors, he understands something about the call of the wild.

Check your article to see that you have quoted, paraphrased, and summarized accurately.

Quote, Paraphrase, and Respond

Choose two passages from the text that remind you of yourself or a friend or relative. Write each passage down as a correctly punctuated direct quotation. Then paraphrase the material in your own words. Finally, respond to the idea expressed in the passage by agreeing or disagreeing with it and explaining why. You may choose to use this material in your article.

- Direct Quotation:
- Paraphrase:
- Response to the idea expressed in a passage by agreeing or disagreeing with it and explaining why:

Activity 49: Negotiating Voices – Using Model Language

The following activity can help you put direct quotations, indirect quotations, concepts, facts, ideas, and opinions from other writers into your own texts while keeping all the voices distinct. Study the following templates. Then, return to your article. Examine the uses of quotations, paraphrase, or summary in your article and revise, if needed, to keep the voices distinct. Work with a partner to check each other's work. If you and your partner do not agree on the best language to use, ask another pair for their opinion.

- The issue of McCandless's motivations for going into the wild without sufficient food or equipment can be viewed from several different perspectives.
- Experts disagree on what caused McCandless's death.

You might then use language that introduces ideas from particular writers:

- Journalist Jon Krakauer argues that...
- In his original article, Krakauer states that McCandless ate poisonous seeds. However, later.
- According to cross-country teammate Andy Horowitz, McCandless was born in the wrong century.

Signal contrary views by adding transitional phrases:

- The roots of the wild potato are edible. However, the data presented by John Bryant, a chemical ecologist, show that a plant can have edible roots but poisonous seeds.
- On the other hand, Krakauer believes...

To add your own voice to the mix:

- Although some argue that McCandless trashed the cabins, others argue that he was never in the area. In my view...
- Though researchers disagree, clearly...

Revising Rhetorically

Activity 50: Analyzing Your Draft Rhetorically / Gathering and Responding to Feedback

You will now need to work with the organization and development of your draft to make sure your article is as effective as possible.

Peer Group Work

Break into groups of four. Each student will read his or her article aloud to the other members of the group. After listening to the article, discuss the following questions:

- How does the introduction hook the reader and give a purpose to continue reading?
- Who is being compared and is the comparison logical?
- How is the comparison structured? Does the writer give several points about McCandless and then add points about the one being compared/contrasted? Does the writer compare/contrast main points as he/she goes? Either style is acceptable but consistency is important.
- What is the thesis of the article? What point does the writer make?
- What support does the writer provide for the thesis?
- Are you persuaded by the writer's argument?

How is narrative used in the article?

- Are effective transitions used to make comparisons?

Examples of transitions that compare are

- Similarly
- In the same way
- Correspondingly
- Likewise

Examples of transitions that show contrasts are

- On the other hand
- Conversely
- However
- Meanwhile
- In contrast

- How does the writer address counterclaims? If the readers disagree with the thesis or the validity of support have their concerns been addressed?
- What value do you feel you have gained from reading the article?
- What do you like best about the article?

- What could the writer do to improve the article?

Paired Work

Work in pairs to decide how you want to revise the problems group members have identified.

Individual Work

Revise the draft on the basis of the feedback you have received and the decisions you have made with your partners. Consider these additional questions for your individual work:

- Have you responded to the assignment?
- What is your purpose for this article?
- What should you keep? What is most effective?
- What should you add? Where do you need more anecdotes, examples, and other evidence to support your point?
- What could you omit? Did you use irrelevant details? Were you repetitive?
- What should you change? Are parts of your article confusing or contradictory?
- Do you need to explain your ideas more fully?
- How is your tone? Are you too overbearing, too firm?
- Does your conclusion show the significance of your article?

Activity 51: Analyzing Your Draft Rhetorically – Considering Stylistic Choices

Writers make stylistic choices in order to enhance the clarity of their messages, make emotional connections with readers, and establish their ethos. These choices draw readers in or push them away. You can consider the effectiveness of their stylistic choices by responding to the following questions:

- How will the language you have used affect your reader's response?
- Which words or synonyms have you repeated? Why?
- What figurative language have you used? Why did you use it?
- What effects will your choices of sentence structure and length have on the reader?
- In what ways does your language help convey your identity and character as a writer?
- Is your language appropriate for your intended audience?

Editing

Activity 52: Editing Your Draft

You will now need to work with the grammar, punctuation, and mechanics of your draft to make sure your article conforms to the guidelines of standard written English.

Edit your draft on the basis of the information you have received from your teacher or classmates. The suggestions below will also help you edit your own work.

Editing Guidelines for Individual Work

- If possible, set your article aside for 24 hours before rereading it to find errors.
- If possible, read your article aloud to a friend so you can hear your errors.
- Use a sheet of paper to cover everything except the line you are reading. Then touch your pencil to each word as you read.
- Work with a partner to identify your pattern of errors—the most serious and frequent errors you make.
- Look for only one type of error at a time. Then go back and look for a second type and, if necessary, a third.
- Spell-check or use an online dictionary to check spelling and confirm that you have chosen the right word for the context. Check an online thesaurus for alternate words.

Activity 53: Preparing Your Draft for Publication – Responding to Feedback

Consider all of the feedback you have received from others and make decisions about what changes you are going to make in your final draft.

- What are the main concerns your readers had in reading your draft?
- Do all of the readers agree?
- What global changes should you consider (thesis, arguments, evidence, organization)?
- What do you need to add?
- What do you need to delete?
- What sentence-level and stylistic problems do you need to correct?
- What kinds of grammar and usage errors do you have? How can you correct them?
- What is your next move toward improving this paper?

Activity 54: Reflecting on Your Writing Process

When you have completed your article, answer the following six questions. Write your answers in your *Into the Wild* notebook.

1. What was most difficult about this assignment?
2. What was easiest?
3. What did you learn about arguing by completing this assignment?
4. What do you think are the strengths of your argument? Place a wavy line by the parts of your article you feel are very good.
5. What are the weaknesses, if any, of your paper? Place an X by the parts of your article you would like help with. Write any questions you have in the margin.
6. What did you learn from this assignment about your own writing process—about preparing to write, about writing the first draft, about revising, and about editing?

Activity 55: Reflecting on Your Learning Goals

Return to your notebooks for a final reflection on your progress toward reaching your goals for this module. Share with a partner specific examples of the progress you have made. You may use evidence such as your final writing task. How have you become more prepared for life, college, or the workforce by reading this book and taking part in the learning? Choose to write a short letter, email, or a tweet expressing your final learning. Direct the writing to eleventh graders who may be reading this book next year.